AUTHOR'S NOTE

In 1843, shortly after his return from the slaughterhouse of the First Anglo-Afghan War, the army chaplain in Jalalabad, the Rev. G. R. Gleig, wrote a memoir about the disastrous expedition of which he was one of the lucky survivors. It was, he wrote, 'a war begun for no wise purpose, carried on with a strange mixture of rashness and timidity, brought to a close after suffering and disaster, without much glory attached either to the government which directed, or the great body of troops which waged it. Not one benefit, political or military, has been acquired with this war. Our eventual evacuation of the country resembled the retreat of an army defeated.'[1]

William Barnes Wollen's celebrated painting of the *Last Stand of the 44th Foot* – a group of ragged but doggedly determined soldiers on the hilltop of Gandamak standing encircled behind a thin line of bayonets, as the Pashtun tribesmen close in – became one of the era's most famous images, along with *Remnants of an Army*, Lady Butler's oil of the alleged last survivor, Dr Brydon, arriving before the walls of Jalalabad on his collapsing nag.

It was just as the latest western invasion of Afghanistan was beginning to turn sour in the winter of 2006, that I had the idea of writing a new history of Britain's first failed attempt at controlling Afghanistan. After an easy conquest and the successful installation of a pro-western puppet ruler, the regime was facing increasingly widespread resistance. History was beginning to repeat itself.

In the course of the initial research I visited many of the places associated with the war. On my first day in Afghanistan I drove through the Shomali Plain to see the remains of Eldred Pottinger's barracks at Charikar, which now lie a short distance from the US Air Force base at Bagram. In Herat I paid my respects at the grave of Dost Mohammad Khan, at the Sufi shrine of Gazur Gah. In Jalalabad I sat by the Kabul River and ate the same delicious *shir maheh* river fish, grilled on charcoal, which 170 years earlier had sustained the British troops besieged there and which had been particularly popular with 'Fighting Bob' Sale. On arrival in Kandahar, the car sent to pick me up from the airport received a sniper shot through its